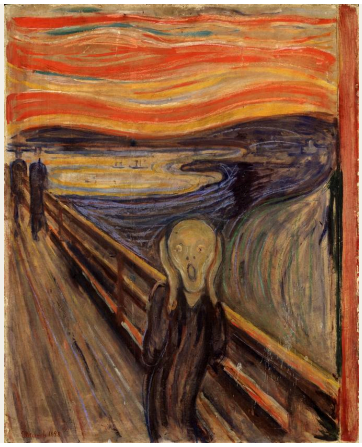
OSLO, NORWAY

National Museum: Masterpieces

Windows, railings, shorelines and imagined gardens divide one kind of space from another.



The railing in *The Scream* offers a firm diagonal through a world of wavering contours. Elsewhere, a balcony contains a quiet winter prospect, and a church doorway joins a dim interior to daylight. These boundaries are more than convenient parts of a setting. They establish where a figure stands, what can be reached, and how an outside world enters a picture.

This selection moves among Munch, Backer, the Krohgs, Kielland and several landscape and fairy-tale subjects. It does not ask every image to illustrate anxiety. A threshold may organise ordinary work or communal life just as effectively as it can intensify estrangement. The differences deserve as much attention as the recurring forms.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-museum-oslo

The selection · 20

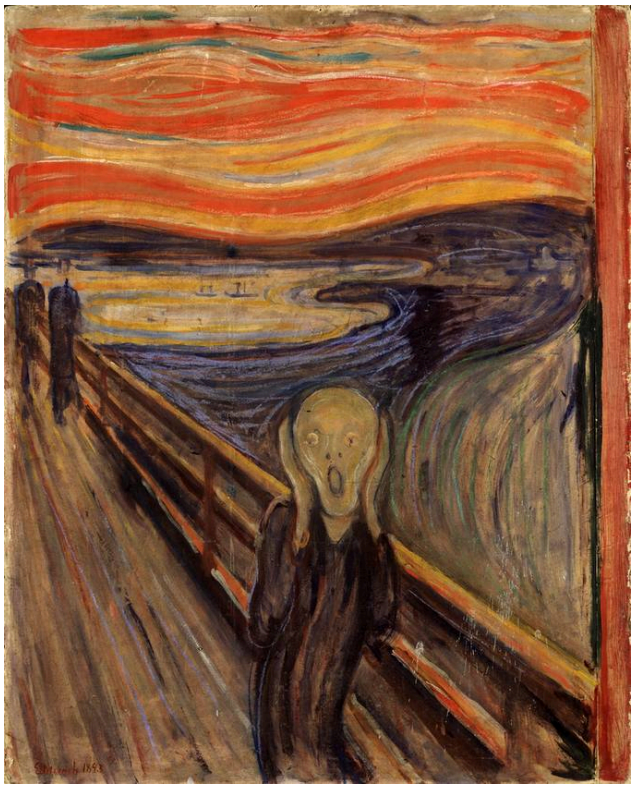
1. The Scream
   Edvard Munch · 1893
2. Madonna
   Edvard Munch · 1894
3. Rue Lafayette
   Edvard Munch · 1891
4. Spring
   Edvard Munch · 1889
5. Sister Inger
   Edvard Munch · 1884
6. Blue Interior
   Harriet Backer · 1883
7. Christening in Tanum Church
   Harriet Backer · 1892
8. By Lamplight
   Harriet Backer · 1890
9. A Japanese Lantern
   Oda Krohg · 1886
10. Christian Krohg at the Easel
    Oda Krohg · 1885–1890
11. Soria Moria Palace
    Theodor Kittelsen · 1900
12. The Ash Lad and the Fox
    Theodor Kittelsen · 1900
13. Winter on the Balcony
    Harald Sohlberg · 1899
14. Stetind in Mist
    Peder Balke · 1865
15. Lighthouse on the Norwegian Coast
    Peder Balke · 1850–1860
16. Summer Night
    Kitty Lange Kielland · 1886
17. View over the Sea from Ogna, Jæren
    Kitty Lange Kielland · 1878
18. Balestrand
    Hans Gude · 1848
19. A Forest
    Lars Hertervig · 1853
20. The Golden Age
    Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1530

01 / 20

The Scream

Edvard Munch

1893 · Tempera and wax crayon on cardboard · National Museum



Edvard Munch, The Scream. National Museum, Oslo. Reproduction via Wikimedia Commons (PD-Art). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · Public Domain Mark 1.0 / PD-Art

The railing's straight line offers a route through the scene, but the sky and water refuse its stability. Munch brings their curves into a close relationship with the open-mouthed figure holding its head. Distress no longer seems confined to one body. The composition makes the surroundings participate, without requiring a literal claim that the landscape is producing an audible sound.

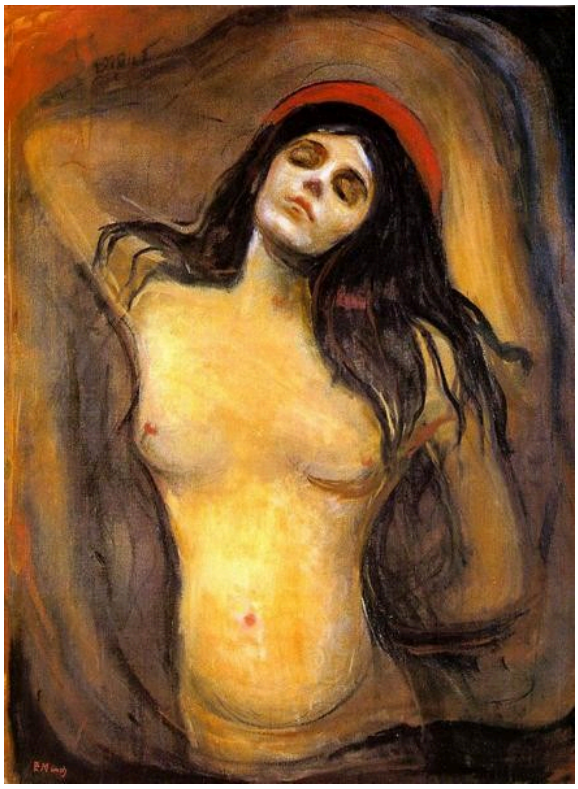
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00939

02 / 20

Madonna

Edvard Munch

1894 · Oil on canvas · National Museum



Edvard Munch. Madonna. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sacred title meets a partly exposed body enclosed by dark hair and shadow. A red halo-like form adds to the unresolved relation between devotional reference and flesh. Munch's tilted head and suspended pose do not settle into a single familiar category. The ambiguity is grounded in what the image joins, rather than in a missing explanatory anecdote.

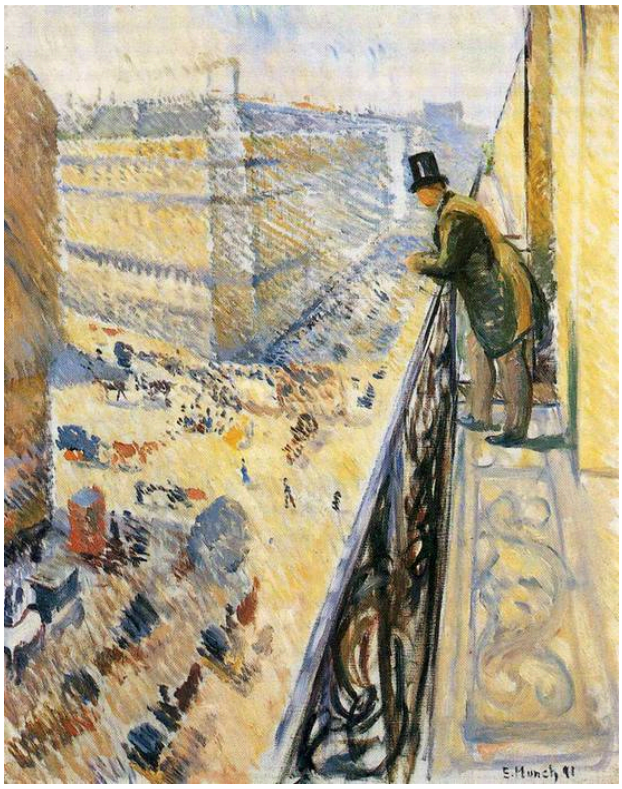
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00841

03 / 20

Rue Lafayette

Edvard Munch

1891 · Oil on canvas · National Museum



Edvard Munch. Street Lafayette. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edvard-munch/street-lafayette-1891 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The man on the balcony has a view of urban activity from which he remains physically separate. Far below, short coloured strokes make the street busy but prevent each passer-by from receiving a distinct account. Munch makes distance an organising condition of looking. The city becomes a field of movement beneath an observer who is comparatively still.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Spring

Edvard Munch

1889 · National Museum



Edvard Munch. Spring. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The bright window and moving curtain bring the outside close to the pale young woman and her older companion. Munch lets illness and care share a room with signs of renewed air. The contrast does not guarantee recovery. Brightness can alter the conditions around a vulnerable figure without resolving the condition the figure occupies.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Sister Inger

Edvard Munch

1884 · National Museum



Edvard Munch. Sister Inger. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The dark dress nearly joins the background, leaving the face and hands to establish the figure's position. Their unequal placement prevents those light areas from becoming a symmetrical emblem. Munch makes a portrait out of restrained differences within darkness. The limited setting concentrates the sitter's presence while giving little warrant for assigning her a particular private mood.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Blue Interior

Harriet Backer

1883 · National Museum



Harriet Backer. Blue Interior. Image credit: Harriet Backer; Source credit: hgEgkxpd_4iyCA at Google Cultural Institute , zoom level maximum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The red writing desk gives the cool room a distinct point of contrast, but Backer does not make the seated woman the only recipient of attention. Furnishings, pictures and intervals of light remain substantial subjects. The figure belongs to the room's arrangement. Colour connects her with a space whose interest does not depend entirely on what she might be thinking.

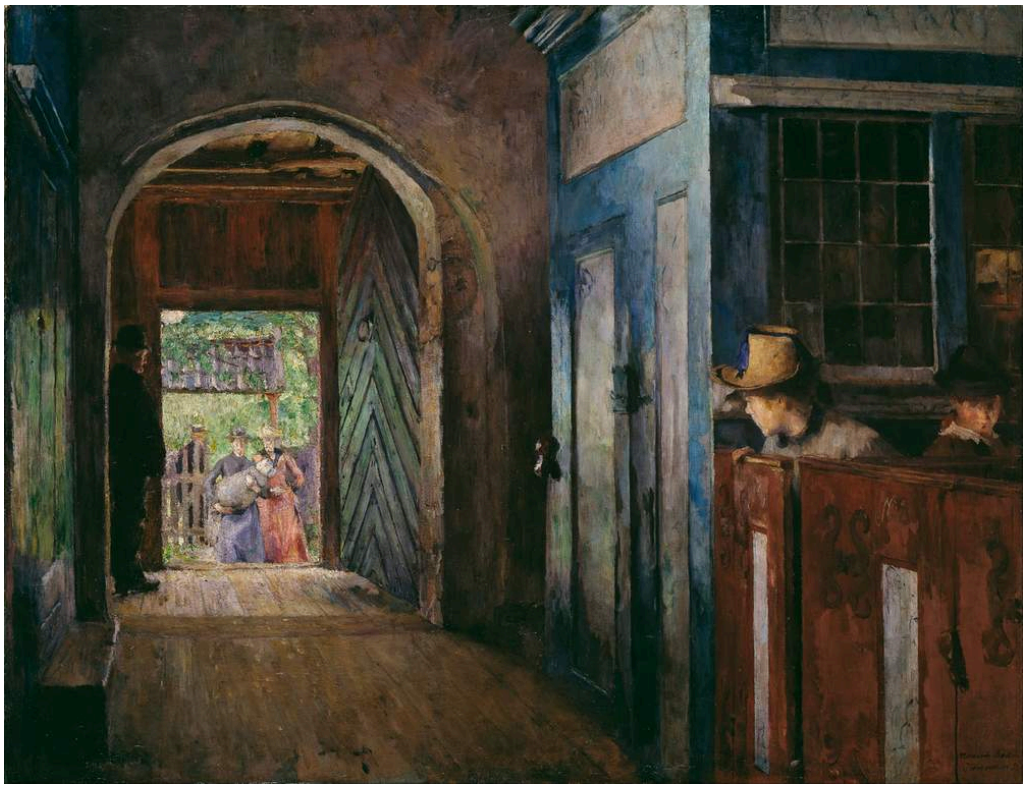
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.02582

07 / 20

Christening in Tanum Church

Harriet Backer

1892 · National Museum



Harriet Backer. Christening in Tanum Church. Image credit: Harriet Backer; Source credit: HwFRac5hmtoV0w at Google Cultural Institute , zoom level maximum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The doorway joins bright outdoor figures to people already seated in the dim church. Backer describes a communal event through the spatial conditions that receive it. Successive openings make looking move inward and outward, rather than resting only on the ceremony named in the title. Architecture gives the gathering a sequence of approaches and places to wait.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.02465

08 / 20

By Lamplight

Harriet Backer

1890 · National Museum



Harriet Backer. By Lamp Light. Image credit: Harriet Backer; Source credit: OgEFw8dGHdBwQw at Google Cultural Institute , zoom level maximum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The lamp's reach and the woman's attention meet at the task. Hands and profile receive enough warm light to make the working posture clear, while much of the room stays subdued. Backer gives concentration a visible boundary. The surrounding darkness need not signify isolation; it also distinguishes useful light from space not immediately required by the activity.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.02323

09 / 20

A Japanese Lantern

Oda Krohg

1886 · National Museum



Oda Krohg. A Japanese Lantern. Image credit: Oda Krohg; Source credit: fwGBNpCfAil86w at Google Cultural Institute , zoom level maximum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Warm artificial light hangs before the cooler water and trees beyond the opening. Oda Krohg makes two conditions coexist without blending them into a single atmosphere. The seated woman remains inside that meeting of lights. The threshold establishes a relationship between interior and evening rather than simply separating a room from its view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00879

10 / 20

Christian Krohg at the Easel

Oda Krohg

1885–1890 · National Museum



Oda Krohg. Christian Krohg at the Easel. Image credit: Oda Krohg. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The sitter's attention stays with the canvas, leaving the viewer to see him from the side. Palette, chair and posture identify artistic work without the formality of a public studio portrait. Oda Krohg keeps the outdoor surroundings loose. The practical arrangement is enough to give the occupied body a clear place and purpose.

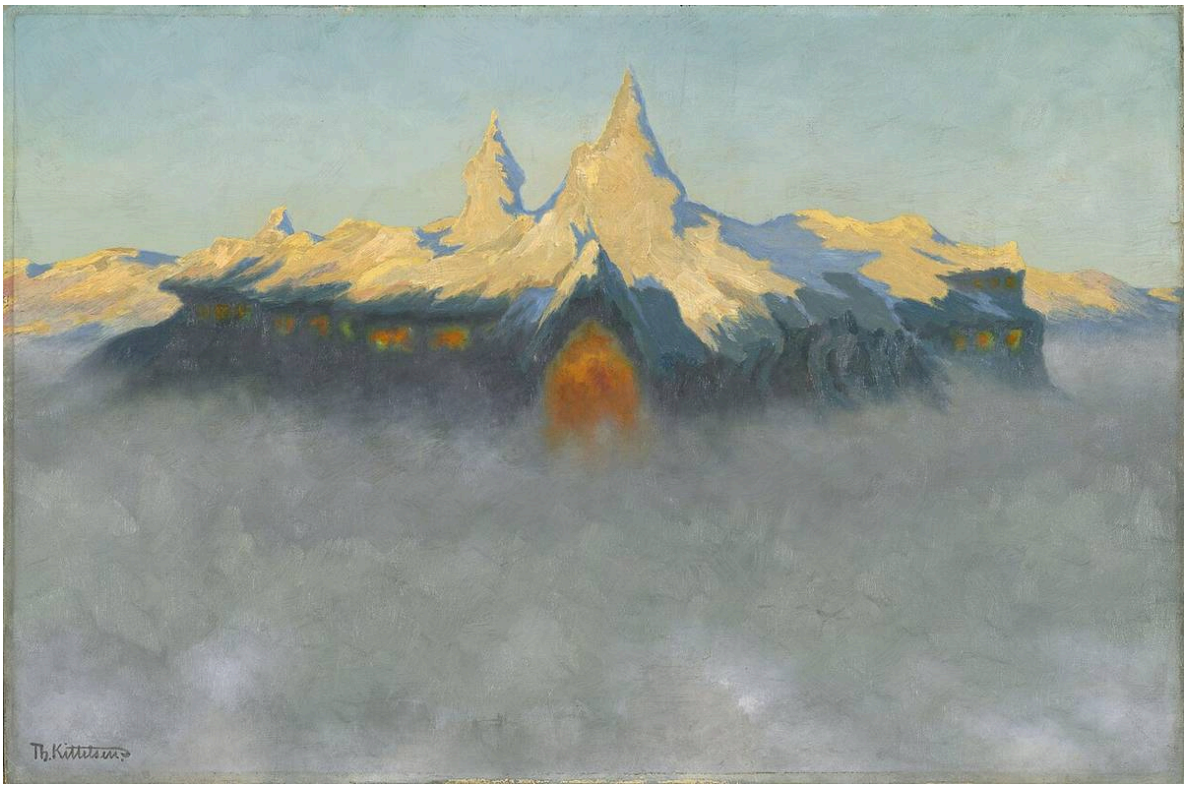
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMK.2020.0293

11 / 20

Soria Moria Palace

Theodor Kittelsen

1900 · National Museum



Theodor Kittelsen. Soria Moria Palace. Image credit: Theodor Kittelsen; Source credit: National Museum of Art, Architecture and Design. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The golden towers are sharply available to sight, but mist hides the structure that would connect them to a reachable place. Kittelsen makes the destination visible and inaccessible at the same time. Its fairy-tale character depends partly on that missing approach. Brightness promises recognition while the concealed base prevents an ordinary understanding of how to get there.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00551

12 / 20

The Ash Lad and the Fox

Theodor Kittelsen

1900 · National Museum



Theodor Kittelsen. The Ash Lad and the Fox. Image credit: Theodor Kittelsen; Source credit: National Museum of Art, Architecture and Design. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The boy and upright fox face one another in a woodland clearing, their pause giving the encounter a familiar social shape. Kittelsen needs little spectacular scenery to introduce the tale's impossibility. A recognisable path and the distance between two figures are enough. The unusual participant enters a setting whose scale otherwise remains plausible.

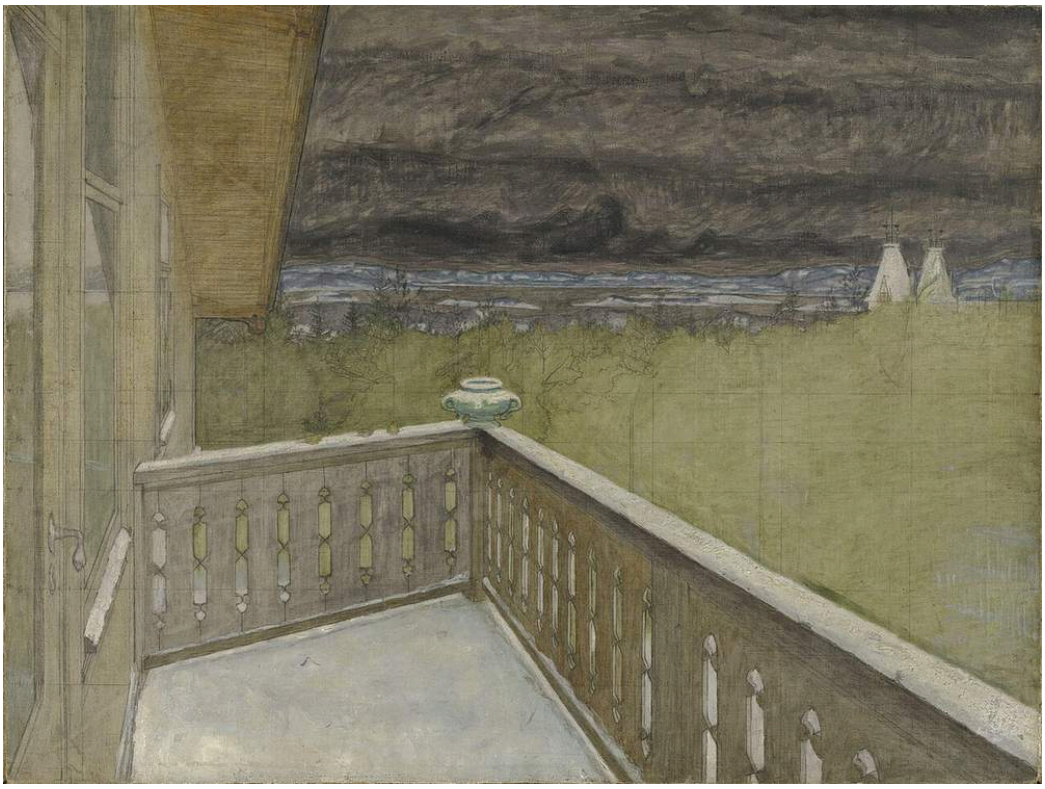
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00547

13 / 20

Winter on the Balcony

Harald Sohlberg

1899 · National Museum



Harald Sohlberg. Winter on the Balcony. Image credit: Harald Sohlberg; Source credit: Nasjonalmuseet for kunst, arkitektur og design. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The railing stays close and definite while the water and ground beyond offer little activity. Sohlberg makes the protected vantage point part of the landscape rather than removing it for an unobstructed prospect. The view belongs to someone at a boundary, not to an eye floating freely outdoors. Muted colour reinforces the separation without explaining it as one fixed emotion.

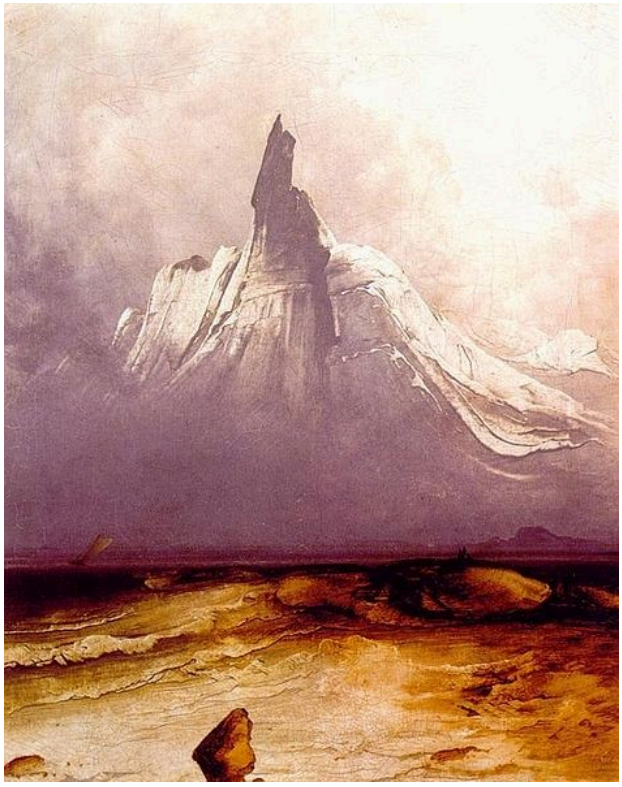
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMK.2021.0434

14 / 20

Stetind in Mist

Peder Balke

1865 · National Museum



Peder Balke. Stetind in Mist. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The pointed peak is clearer than much of the terrain supporting it. Balke lets haze remove information so that a decisive outline can establish the mountain's presence. Dark shore and pale distance give it scale through contrast. The scene's force comes from selective definition, not from an equally detailed account of every part of a vast place.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Lighthouse on the Norwegian Coast

Peder Balke

1850–1860 · National Museum



Lighthouse on the Norwegian Coast. Peder Balke; Source credit: National Museum of Art, Architecture and Design. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

The lighthouse offers a thin upright against the broad movements of water and cloud. Its smallness makes the coast's turbulence easier to measure. Balke gives the building a legible pale form but little power to command its surroundings. A structure meant to assist navigation appears within conditions that are visibly larger than its reach.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.01320

16 / 20

Summer Night

Kitty Lange Kielland

1886 · National Museum



Kitty Lange Kielland. Summer Night. Image credit: Kitty Lange Kielland; Source credit: PwGtQgwyhKNSTw at Google Cultural Institute , zoom level maximum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Kielland sustains the evening through close tonal relationships rather than a spectacular point of light. Reeds, lilies and reflections introduce small differences across the water's edge. The scene asks for attention to those variations instead of a dramatic event. Stillness is not an absence of information; it changes the scale at which the information becomes worth following.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00357

17 / 20

View over the Sea from Ogna, Jæren

Kitty Lange Kielland

1878 · National Museum



Kitty Lange Kielland. View over the Sea from Ogna, Jæren. Image credit: Kitty Lange Kielland; Source credit: National Museum of Art, Architecture and Design. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Rounded rocks and shallow channels complicate the near ground before the eye reaches the open sea. Kielland makes that approach tangible through irregular surfaces and low vegetation. The horizon is comparatively simple, but the foreground refuses a quick passage. A coast can be understood from what lies close to the feet as well as from a distant prospect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.00975

18 / 20

Balestrand

Hans Gude

1848 · National Museum



Hans Gude. Balestrand. Image credit: Hans Gude. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Small figures and buildings establish a familiar scale at the shore before the mountains enlarge it. Gude separates the near rock, water and slopes into readable distances, with light distinguishing selected areas. The fjord is substantial without becoming shapeless magnitude. Habitation supplies a foothold from which the long passage across the landscape can be judged.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMK.2021.0108

19 / 20

A Forest

Lars Hertervig

1853 · National Museum



Lars Hertervig. A Forest. Image credit: Lars Hertervig; Source credit: EwG0W3HsCM_1KA at Google Cultural Institute , zoom level maximum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The foreground trees enclose much of the view, but a distant opening and pale band of cloud prevent complete closure. Hertervig distributes visibility unevenly. Attention has to negotiate dense masses before finding brightness beyond them, so the forest's tension belongs to the arrangement itself. No invented event in the woods is needed to explain that difficulty of access.

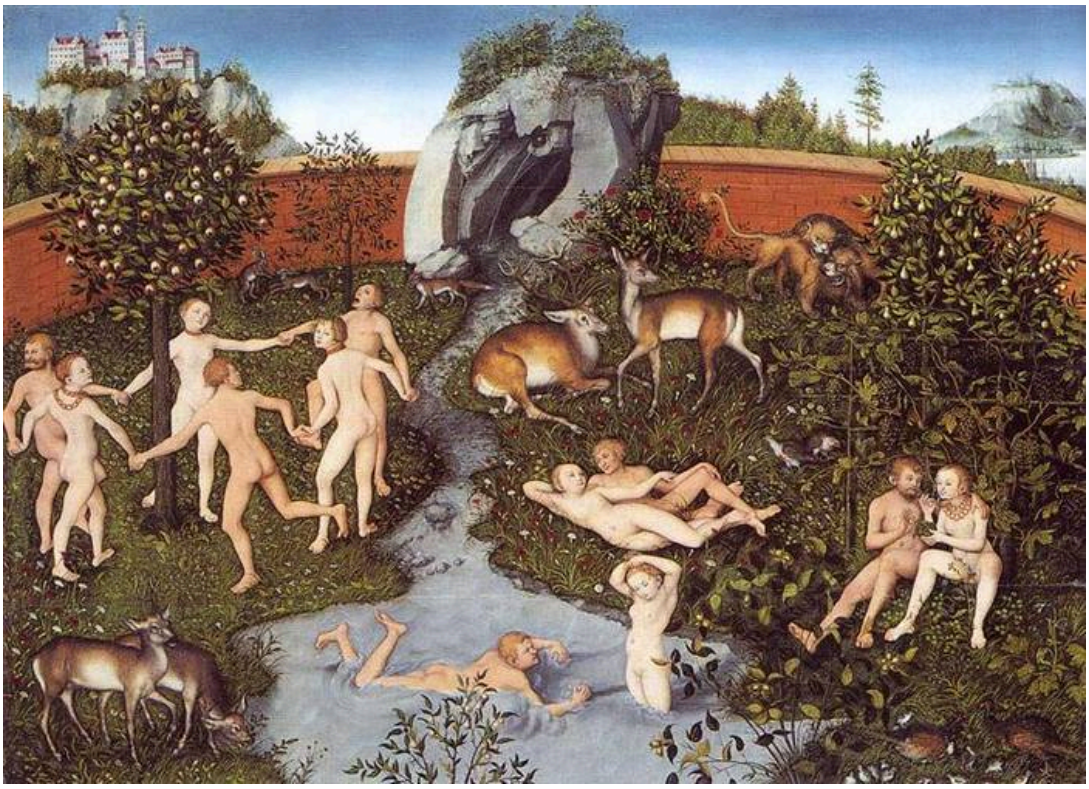
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG.M.02009

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The Golden Age

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1530 · Oil on wood · National Museum



The Golden Age. WikiArt; Lucas Cranach the Elder. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Resting, dancing and bathing figures share a garden with animals and fruit trees. Cranach makes the imagined harmony concrete through different untroubled activities, then places a wall around it. The boundary deserves attention: this ideal world is visibly set apart. Its ease depends on an arranged enclosure, not on a claim to record ordinary life outside it.

Object source · Open artwork

Follow a boundary

Choose a window, shore or railing and trace what changes across it. The exercise connects these works without making them illustrations of one national mood. This selection concerns the National Museum's collection, not the separate MUNCH collection or a fixed current hanging. Confirm particular works and access through the museum before visiting.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s chapters on tone, line and composition supply a practical vocabulary for comparing Backer’s illuminated interiors with Balke’s compressed landscapes. The book is a way into those differences, not evidence of direct influence.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
